

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 4
♥ J 8 6 3
♦ T 5
♣ 9 8 4 3

♠ T 6 3

♥ A T 7 5 4

♦ A J 2

♣ A K



♠ K Q J 8

♥ -

♦ 9 7 6 4

♣ Q T 6 5 2

♠ 9 5 2

♥ K Q 9 2

♦ K Q 8 3

♣ J 7

West

North

East

South

Pass

1 ♥

Pass

3 ♥

All Pass

4 ♥ by North

You have 12 points which isn't quite enough to force to game.

It is just right for a limit raise though, so you bid 3 ♥.

Partner does bid the game.

South would play 4 ♥.

Click

North plays 4 ♥. The defense takes the first three ♠ tricks, then switches to a ♣.

North plays 4 ♥. The defense takes the first three ♠ tricks, then switches to a ♣.

Losers: ♠ 3 : ♥ ?? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3+??

With no more outside losers your task is very very simple:**DO NOT LOSE A TRUMP TRICK.**

There is no problem if trumps split 2-2 or 3-1, so you can put your mind to 4-0 splits only. If East holds ♥ J 8 6 3 then it won't matter whether your first trump play is ♥ A or ♥ K, you will still be able to finesse the ♥ J. But if West holds ♥ J 8 6 3 it is vital that you first play either the ♥ K or ♥ Q. If you start with the ♥ A you will have lost your finesse position. The general rule is to first play a high trump from the hand that has two. That preserves a finesse through either defender's ♥ J x x x.

Visualize the situation if your first play was the ♥ A. East would show out and you would learn that West held ♥ J 8 6 3 but you couldn't do anything about it.

Next visualize the situation if your first play was the ♥ K. East would show out and you would play the ♥ Q, then a small ♥ finessing your ♥ 10.

Finally visualize the situation if your first play was the ♥ K and it was West who showed out. You would play a small ♥ to your ♥ A, then lead a ♥ toward dummy finessing with the ♥ 9.

Using the correct Plan guarantees the contract however ♥s split.

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K Q 9 2

♥ 9 5 2

♦ K 7

♣ K Q 8 3

♠ -

♥ A 8 7 4

♦ Q J 6 3 2

♣ T 7 6 4

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♠ A 8 7 5 4

♥ T 6 3

♦ A 8

♣ A J 2

♠ J T 6 3

♥ K Q J

♦ T 9 5 4

♣ 9 5

West

1 ♣

2 ♠

All Pass

4 ♠ by East

only worried about a 4-0 trump split. The reason that it shows up right here is to point out the difference between J 8 6 3 and J 10 6 3.

North

Pass

Pass

East

1 ♠

4 ♠

South

Pass

Partner has opened and you have 14 points. You know you belong in game but there is no need to jump and use up bidding space. You respond 1 ♠.

Partner now bids 2 ♠.

You know you should be in game and now you know the suit. You bid 4 ♠.

East plays 4 ♠. The defense quickly takes three ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

East plays 4 ♠. The defense quickly takes three ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

Losers: ♠ 0? : ♥ 3 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3?

This Deal is **VERY** similar to Deal 9 in that you are

If North holds ♠ J 10 6 3 then there is nothing you can do about it - you will go down. If you lead a ♠ from dummy he will "split his honors" by playing the ♠ T. This will force your ♠ A and he can just sit back and wait for his ♠ J to make a trick.

But if it is South with ♠ J 10 6 3 you can keep him from winning a ♠ trick, **IF YOUR FIRST ♠ PLAY IS THE ♠ A**. North shows out and you play a small ♠ toward dummy's ♠ K Q 9. If South plays low you insert the ♠ 9, if he plays one of his honors you win it, then return to your hand and finesse him out of the other honor.

When South holds four trumps you can pick them up if your first ♠ play is the ♠ A.

If your first ♠ was ♠ K or ♠ Q then it would be too late.

When North holds four trumps there is no way to avoid a loser. As soon as you lead the first small ♠ from dummy North will play the ♠ T. That will force your ♠ A and leave him with ♠ J 6 3 behind dummy's ♠ K Q 9.

To summarize: If you are missing J x x x your first play should be from the hand with two honors. Then you will be able to finesse in either direction. If you are missing J 10 x x your first play should be honor from the hand with only one. This will leave you with a double-finesse position in one direction. If the other defender has the trumps there is nothing you can do.

Board 3

East Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 5 4
♥ J 8 3
♦ Q T 3
♣ K T 8 2

♠ K 8 2

♥ 7 5 4

♦ K 9 5 4 2

♣ Q 3



♠ J T 9 7
♥ K Q T 6
♦ J 6
♣ J 5 4

♠ A 6 3

♥ A 9 2

♦ A 8 7

♣ A 9 7 6

West	North	East	South
		Pass	1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣2.

Winner count: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 6

Wow. Things do look a little Acey/Spacey. If the ♦s are 3-2, which is likely, you can establish 2 tricks there. You need one more and the best hope is the ♣Q. There is a very good chance that West led from the ♣K. So with a brief prayer to Brigid (the Goddess of Bridge) you put up the ♣Q. It wins the trick.

Now you are on cruise-control. Play a ♦ to the ♦A. Play another ♦ back to dummy's ♦K (both defenders follow). Now a third ♦ sets up the rest of the suit.

As you can see your plan was the only way to make the contract.

Aces and Spaces is the description you often hear about this hand. But the REAL description is 16 points, balanced. So you open 1NT. Partner replies 2NT.

Partner is INVITING you to bid 3NT. If you have 17 points you should bid 3NT. If you have 15 points you should pass.

With 16 points you must make a judgement. This one is actually easy, despite the negative sound of "Aces and Spaces". In strength terms Aces are undervalued. Instead of being worth 4 points they are actually worth about 4.3 points. So you really do have a 17 point hand, and you bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣2.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A K 7 2
 ♥ A 8 3
 ♦ A Q 7 2
 ♣ 6 2

♠ Q T 4 3
 ♥ 5 4
 ♦ J T 9 6 4
 ♣ 9 5



♠ 8 5
 ♥ J 7 6 2
 ♦ 8 3
 ♣ A K Q 4 3

♠ J 9 6
 ♥ K Q T 9
 ♦ K 5
 ♣ J T 8 7

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♠	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West

Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 3 : Total = 8

Despite the great ♣ suit, you have a 4-card Major. It is your duty to first seek an 8-card Major fit, so you bid 2♣ (Stayman). Partner replies 2♠.

Well, that wasn't the Major suit you were hoping for.

But with 11 points you have enough for game, so you bid 3NT.

East would play 3NT.

Click

West plays 3NT. North leads ♦ J, South plays ♦ K.

West plays 3NT. North leads ♦ J, South plays ♦ K.

Thanks to the opening lead you get an extra ♦ winner. Well, since the finesse would have worked it really isn't extra, it's just nice to know about it early. You need to find one more winner and the ♣ suit beckons. A 3-3 split would be very nice, but a 4-2 is more likely. Even with a 4-2 split you can still make your fifth ♣ good - but you must be careful with entries.

Since you have no immediate problem in any suit you can afford to give up the lead. So you play the ♣2 from your hand and the ♣3 from dummy. In other words, you duck a ♣. Somebody will win this trick cheaply and no doubt play another ♦. You don't mind at all - you win the ♦ Q, the ♠ A K, the ♥ A and dummy's ♣ A K Q 4, all of which are good.

Ducking the first ♣ is the only way to make the contract.

If you played a high ♣ first you would never have an entry back to dummy. You would have been forced to try to get there with the ♥ J but as you can see, that wouldn't work.

If you had just played the ♣s from the top you would have made an overtrick when they split 3-3, but gone down when they split 4-2. Making an overtrick about 40% of the time is a high price to pay for going down the other 60%.